

POU11011 — Final essay
60% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

Dr Noah Buckley

New document — Claude's proposal. The 1,500-word essay and its weight come from the filed module outline; the six draft questions and the writing advice are Claude's. Your Russian Politics syllabus does this well for readings but nothing equivalent exists for essays at first-year level, which is the gap this fills. The questions in particular need your eye.

The short version

Weight	60% of the module mark
Length	1,500 words, 10% either way, excluding references
Questions released	Released in lecture and on Blackboard, in due course
Due	Tuesday 15 December 2026, 23:59 (College assessment session: 11–22 December)
Submission	Word or PDF via Blackboard (Turnitin), Assignment Submission Form as page 1
Exam	There is none. This essay is the end of the module

A sustained argument answering one set question, using the module's toolkit across more than one case. Not recall: take a position, and defend it against the strongest version of the other side.

The questions

[DECISION for Noah — final question list is yours. Six drafts below, one per portable concept, deliberately spanning the whole term so that no student can answer having attended only half of it. Recommend releasing four to six. Each is written to require at least two cases, which is what makes the concept do comparative work rather than illustrative work.]

Answer **one**.

1. **Power.** “The most important exercises of power leave no observable trace.” Is this true, and if it is, how can political science study power at all? Answer with reference to at least two cases. (*Portable concept: the three faces of power; measurement.*)
2. **The state.** Why can some states do things that others cannot? Compare two states and argue whether the difference is best explained by capacity, legitimacy, or something else. (*Portable concept: state capacity; monopoly of legitimate violence.*)
3. **Ideology and identity.** Why do some social differences become political and most never do? Answer with reference to at least two cases, and be explicit about what would count as evidence for your explanation. (*Portable concepts: thin vs thick ideology; primordialism vs constructivism vs instrumentalism.*)
4. **Regimes.** Elections are held in states nobody would call democratic. Are these elections meaningless, or do they do real political work? Answer with reference to at least two authoritarian regimes. (*Portable concepts: repression vs co-optation; the dictator’s dilemma; minimal vs substantive definitions of democracy.*)
5. **Institutions.** “Paper constraints only bind when somebody powerful wants them to.” Assess this claim using the idea of veto players and at least two cases of constitutional or judicial constraint on an executive. (*Portable concepts: veto players; constitutionalism; institutional erosion.*)
6. **Political economy and collective action.** Why do democracies persistently under-supply things that most voters say they want — housing, or climate action, or both? Answer using a collective action or concentrated-interests argument, with at least two cases. (*Portable concepts: median voter and why it fails; collective action.*)

If in doubt about anything here, ask me before the deadline.

How to write it

Most first-year essays lose marks in the same four places.

Have an argument, and put it in the first paragraph

An argument is a claim a reasonable person could disagree with — “power has three faces” is a summary, not an argument. Say in three or four sentences what the question is, what your answer is, and how you will get there.

Answer the question that was set

The most common way to lose marks is writing a good essay about an adjacent topic. Reread the question after your third draft and check that every paragraph is doing work for it.

Use the concepts as tools, not as furniture

A concept earns its place if removing it would break your argument — if a paragraph defines something and never uses it, cut the paragraph. Comparison is where the marks are: two cases treated together beats two cases described in sequence.

Take the other side seriously

State the strongest objection to your argument, and answer it — not a strawman. This is what “critical evaluation” means in the Trinity band descriptors, and the most reliable way from a II.1 into a first.

Structure

Not a template, but this shape works at 1,500 words:

Section	Words	Job
Introduction	~150	Question, answer, route
The concept	~200	Define what you are using and where it comes from
Case 1	~350	Apply it, with specifics
Case 2	~350	Apply it, and compare — do not just repeat
Objection	~250	The strongest counter-argument, and your reply
Conclusion	~150	What follows, and what you are still unsure about

No table of contents, abstract, or subheadings unless they genuinely help — this is an essay, not a report.

Prose

Short sentences, active voice. Spellcheck it, and read it aloud once — you will hear what you cannot see.

Sources and referencing

- **Academic sources, not just the textbook** — the module and recommended readings are the obvious next step.
- **Any consistent citation style** — Harvard, Chicago, APA; the [TCD Library style guide](#) will help.
- **Cite paraphrases, not just quotations.**
- **An alphabetised bibliography**, not counted toward the word limit.
- **Only cite what you have read.**

Sloppy referencing costs marks under the *referencing* criterion; fabricated references are an academic integrity matter.

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	Always fine.
Brainstorming	Permitted. Explore angles, argue with it about your thesis, generate counterarguments to argue against.
Research/learning assistance	Permitted, with a warning. Use it to unpack a concept — then verify against the module readings. Do not ask it for references. Sources must be ones you have actually read.
Writing assistance	Permitted only for text you have already drafted yourself — tightening, grammar, clarity, structural critique of your own draft. Generating a section from a prompt and then editing it is not “writing assistance”; that is the next row. If you use it, add a one-line note in an appendix saying which tool and what for.
Direct AI content inclusion	Not permitted. No AI-generated text in the submitted essay, quoted and cited or otherwise. In 1,500 words every sentence is supposed to be your reasoning.
Other use	Describe it on the form, or ask me before the deadline.

Submission

- Word or PDF, via Blackboard (Turnitin) — not Turnitin.com.
- **Assignment Submission Form as page 1**, plagiarism declaration and GenAI disclosure completed. Without one, not accepted — returned unmarked and treated as not submitted until resubmitted. Does not count toward your word limit.
- **State your word count at the top.** 1,500 words carries a 10% tolerance either way; outside 1,350–1,650 costs up to 5 marks.
- Your name in the file name and at the top.
- Back your work up and keep your submission receipt.

Late penalties, extensions and the plagiarism policy: [module outline](#) — not repeated here.

How it is marked

Marked on **argument** · **use of concepts** · **evidence** · **structure and writing** · **referencing**.